

the conversation. Afterward, he calmly posed for photos and signed autographs for a few children who had been waiting for him.

"When all these people support you, even when you play outside (India), they cheer for you. It's a great feeling and essential for building a player's confidence," Tilak told *Sportstar*.

Similarly, Madhya Pradesh's Avesh Khan and Rajat Patidar have also had extensive conversations with Meghalaya players. Avesh interacted with them immediately after their game, while Patidar chatted with them as he walked from Ground C of the Niranjan Shah Stadium towards the buses via the main ground.

For those unable to catch up post-match, hotel meetups are another option. "I talk to MP's Venkatesh Iyer. All of us interact with these players. We are learning a lot from them," Gani said.

At the start of the tournament, there was palpable excitement surrounding Mohammed Shami, who was returning to professional cricket after an ankle injury that had sidelined him for nearly a year following the 2023 ODI World Cup final. On the

first day, Shami entered the ground to a standing ovation from around 40 people who had gathered above the dugout an hour before Bengal's arrival. After the match, Shami graciously posed for selfies and a group photo with the ground staff.

On another day, after finishing a game against Mizoram at the main ground, India and Punjab's premier fast bowler Arshdeep Singh strolled over to Ground C to briefly watch Bengal play Madhya Pradesh. His arrival took everyone by surprise, including the two security personnel. Three children quickly took advantage of the moment to get autographs before the security staff restricted access. Later, Arshdeep obliged a few fans with selfies before boarding the team bus.

Noisy turnaround

A huge roar erupted at Indore's Holkar Stadium when Krunal Pandya was dismissed by R. Sai Kishore in

the 13th over of Baroda's run chase against Tamil Nadu in a Group B fixture of the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy on November 27. The screams from the crowd were in anticipation of Hardik Pandya — Baroda's No. 6 for this game — stepping onto the turf to bat. Hardik promptly took centre stage, hammering a 30-ball 69 to take his side over the line in a chase of 222.

The 31-year-old has evoked similar responses in all of Baroda's matches in Indore, clearly showing that he is the major attraction in a group that also features other current India players like Axar Patel, Ravi Bishnoi, and Varun Chakravarthy.

This is the same player who was booed at stadiums around India during the IPL six months ago. So, what has changed? Simply put, Hardik is now a World Cup winner.

The all-rounder played a crucial role in India's T20 World Cup triumph in the Caribbean in June.

Given the task of defending 15 runs in the last over of the final against South Africa, he held his nerve and got the job done.

Ever since, Hardik seems to have won the fans back. A happy consequence of this for Baroda in this tournament is that it is being treated like the home team in Indore.

"The environment at the stadium is brilliant," Baroda coach Mukund Parmar said. "So many are turning up to watch Hardik, and they are enjoying it. We are getting a lot of support."



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

HARDIK PANDYA SEEMS TO HAVE WON THE FANS BACK SINCE STARRING IN INDIA'S T20 WORLD CUP WIN IN BARBADOS IN JUNE THIS YEAR